

# Whiskerbound

## Game Design Document

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# 1. Game Summary

## **What is this game?**

Whiskerbound is a 2D top-down pixel-art adventure game where players control a couple trapped inside a magical book along with their cat. The players explore a colorful fantasy kingdom, solve puzzles, fight enemies, and talk to villagers while climbing toward a corrupt king's castle. To progress, players must collect magical beads from their cat's collar that guide them through the world. The ultimate goal is to rescue their cat and escape back to the real world.

## **What does the player do most of the time?**

The player explores environments, switches between two characters, solves cooperative puzzles, fights enemies, and collects beads to progress through levels.

## **What kind of experience are you trying to create?**

An emotional and cozy adventure with moments of tension and challenge, balanced by calm exploration and meaningful character interactions.

## **Why would someone want to play this game instead of another one?**

Whiskerbound stands out through its cooperative character-switching gameplay, emotionally driven story about relationships and trust, and its contrast between a bright, candy-colored world and a deeply corrupt system beneath it.

## 2. Player Experience

**How should the player feel most of the time while playing?**

Curious, emotionally invested, and gently challenged.

**How intense should the experience be?**

*Moderate intensity, with relaxed exploration punctuated by tense combat and puzzle-solving moments.*

**What kind of pace does the game have?**

*A steady, deliberate pace that encourages exploration and thoughtful problem-solving rather than constant action.*

**What do you want the player to remember after they stop playing?**

*A sense of emotional connection—to the characters, the cat, and the idea that cooperation and love can overcome difficult systems.*

## 3. Core Gameplay Loop

**What does the player do over and over again?**

Explore areas → solve puzzles → fight enemies → collect beads → save at altars → progress upward through the world.

**How does the game respond to that action?**

The game rewards players with beads, story progression, health upgrades, and access to new areas.

**What tells the player they are making progress?**

Bead collection, increased health, unlocked paths, story scenes, and reaching higher levels of the kingdom.

### **What causes failure, reset, or pressure?**

Losing all health hearts during combat or exploration results in failure and prevents further progression.

### **What causes pressure or irreversible consequences?**

In the final act, the player is forced into a narrative decision that cannot be undone. This choice determines the fate of:

- Neela
- The prince
- The kingdom
- Yoichi and Shuyi themselves

## **4. Core Mechanics**

### **What mechanics are absolutely required for this game to exist?**

- Character switching between Yoichi and Shuyi
- Movement and exploration
- Combat (attack, shield)
- Puzzle interaction
- Health and skill point systems

- Bead collection and altar progression

**What mechanics help support the experience but are not required?**

- NPC dialogue and lore discovery
- Optional side scenes and emotional moments
- Save points and checkpoints

**What mechanic will the player use the most?**

Character switching to solve puzzles and survive combat.

## 5. Player Goals

**What is the main goal the player is working toward?**

Rescue Neela, defeat the king, restore the cat's collar, and escape the fantasy world.

**What smaller goals guide the player moment to moment?**

- Collect three beads per level
- Solve puzzles and defeat enemies
- Reach altar save points
- Learn about the kingdom and its corruption

### **How does the player know they are making progress?**

Visual bead counters, health upgrades, unlocked areas, and story events.

### **What happens if the player ignores the main goal?**

The game allows exploration and side interactions, but progression is ultimately blocked without bead collection.

## **6. World & Theme**

### **Where does this game take place?**

Inside a magical, candy-themed fantasy kingdom contained within an enchanted book, structured like a towering mountain.

### **What ideas or themes does the game explore?**

Love, collaboration, perseverance, political corruption, inequality, and the cost of immortality.

In addition to love, collaboration, and perseverance, the game now more deeply explores **power, sacrifice, manipulation, and moral choice**. The king's obsession with youth and control highlights how those in power exploit others to preserve authority. The final act forces players to confront the cost of their choices—questioning whether personal love, political stability, or truth should take priority.

### **What tone should the world have?**

Visually cozy, colorful, and sweet, contrasted with a dark, morally corrupted reality.

### **Why does this world fit the gameplay?**

The vertical structure supports progression, the cooperative themes mirror the gameplay mechanics, and the contrast between beauty and corruption reinforces puzzle-solving and narrative discovery.

## 7. Characters - Universal Template

**What role does this character play in the game?**

**Yoichi**

- **Role:** Playable character (Warrior)
- **Gameplay purpose:** Physical combat, protection, strength-based puzzles
- **Player interaction:** Direct control
- **Frequency:** Constant

**Shuyi**

- **Role:** Playable character (Mage)
- **Gameplay purpose:** Magic, puzzle-solving, strategy
- **Player interaction:** Direct control
- **Frequency:** Constant

**Neela**

- **Role:** Motivation and narrative anchor
- **Gameplay purpose:** Bead system, story progression
- **Player interaction:** Story-driven, indirect
- **Frequency:** Appears in story scenes

## King

- **Role:** Antagonist
- **Gameplay purpose:** Final boss, source of the kingdom's corruption, driver of the moral dilemma
- **Player interaction:** Story confrontation, boss fight, and choice-based narrative
- **Frequency:** Limited, climactic, referenced throughout the game; appears directly in the final act

### Description:

The king is obsessed with eternal youth and power. After banishing his only son, he discovers life-force extraction through magical rituals performed by royal magicians. Later, he encounters Neela, whose natural magic restores his youth more efficiently. He seeks to permanently fuse with the cat to secure immortality.

## The Prince

- **Role:** Companion NPC, hidden heir to the throne
- **Gameplay purpose:** Narrative guide, moral anchor, and catalyst for the final choice
- **Player interaction:** Dialogue, guidance, story scenes
- **Frequency:** Appears consistently from early game through the final act

### Description:

The prince is the king's banished son, cast into the slums for opposing his father's cruel rule. Disguised as a kind and helpful companion, he aids Yoichi and Shuyi throughout their journey. He believes the kingdom deserves to be freed from corruption—even if it costs him his life.

## 8. Level Structure

### **How is the game laid out?**

Structured, semi-linear levels with exploration paths and village hubs.

### **How does the player move forward through the game?**

Collecting beads, completing challenges, and activating altar save points.

### **How does the game become more challenging over time?**

More complex puzzles, stronger enemies, and reduced guidance as players ascend.

### **Are there optional or side areas? Why?**

Yes. Side areas provide lore, emotional scenes, and optional challenges.

### **Final Act Structure:**

- Throne Room confrontation
- Interrupted fusion ceremony between the king and Neela
- Dialogue-driven choice with three outcomes
- Ending cutscene based on player decision

## 9. UI / UX

### **What information only shows up when needed?**

Interaction prompts, puzzle hints, dialogue boxes.

### **What information does the player always see?**

Health and skill points, beads collected, character icon, movement joystick, action buttons.

### **How does the game show success or failure?**

Visual effects, sound cues, health changes, and game-over states.

### **What should the UI never distract the player from?**

The emotional tone, exploration flow, and cooperative focus.

## 10. Audio

### **What role does sound play in this game?**

Audio reinforces emotion, immersion, and tension.

### **When should sound be quiet or absent?**

Story scenes, emotional checkpoints, and reflective conversations.

### **How does audio affect emotion or tension?**

Soft music for exploration, tense tracks for combat, warm tones for safe areas.

## 11. Accessibility

### **Who might have trouble playing this game?**

Players with motor impairments, visual sensitivity, or difficulty with multitasking.

### **What accessibility options do you want to support?**

- Simple touchscreen controls
- Clear UI icons
- Consistent color coding

### **What accessibility limits exist right now?**

Advanced accessibility features (e.g., full remapping, colorblind modes) may not be fully supported.

## 12. Technical Basics

### **What engine is the game made in?**

Unity

### **What platforms will the game run on?**

PC and Mobile

### **How does the player control the game?**

On-screen joystick and buttons for movement, combat, interaction, shield, and character switching.

## 13. Scope & Risk

**What needs to exist for this game to feel complete?**

- All levels
- Bead system
- Character switching
- Final boss and ending

**What could realistically stop this game from being finished?**

Time constraints, complexity of cooperative puzzle design, motivation sustainability.

**What feature are you choosing not to make?**

Online multiplayer or additional playable characters.

## 14. Ending Structure

**Ending 1: Sacrifice the Prince (Bad Ending)**

The prince accepts death to help the couple save Neela. The king reveals the truth too late—he has eliminated his only rival. The couple is captured and killed. The king completes the fusion and rules forever.

### Ending 2: Do Nothing (Neutral / Gray Ending)

The couple refuses to act. The king completes the ceremony, preserving surface-level peace. Neela remains trapped. The kingdom survives, but corruption continues.

### Ending 3: Mystery Option (True Ending)

The prince reveals his identity and past banishment. The truth of the kingdom is exposed. The king is confronted, Neela is freed, and the cycle of corruption is broken.

## 15. Brain Dump

What doesn't fit anywhere else?

The prince's identity is intentionally hidden to build trust and emotional impact

The king's offer is meant to manipulate both the characters and the player

The "Sacrifice the Prince" ending is a **trap ending**—punishing blind obedience and emotional desperation

The mystery option represents truth, rebellion, and breaking the cycle rather than choosing between two evils

## 16. Motivation

Start small.

Finish something.

Then decide what's next.

